

successful at committing crimes, and more easily detected; police may be more likely to arrest mentally ill offenders; guilty pleas may be easier to obtain from mentally ill offenders; or the deprivations of prison might *cause* the mental illness. Research indicates that rates of offending in psychiatric hospital populations are generally higher than in the general population. Again, this finding does not in itself prove that mental illness *causes* crime. Early research actually suggested that psychiatric populations committed crimes at the same rate as the general population; the more recent research indicating that rates of robbery (and possibly rape) are higher among psychiatric populations may say more about who is institutionalized in psychiatric facilities than about rates of crime. In the future, careful research design may disaggregate the concepts of mental illness, crime, and institutionalization, and allow scientists to separate cause from correlation, but the relationship between mental illness and crime currently remains equivocal.

The psychological causes of crime remain a rich area of investigation. Contemporary research is already exploring the neurological bases of psychological phenomena such as psychopathy, intelligence, and personality. As biological and psychological explanations converge, the mechanisms of the individual level causes of crime may become clear. Psychological criminologists also may bridge individual level and interpersonal explanations to explain, for example, how personality traits contribute to the social bonds that underlie social control theory or how intelligence contributes to the trajectory of a criminal life course.

SEE ALSO: Crime, Biosocial Theories of; Crime, Social Learning Theory of; Freud, Sigmund; Law, Criminal; Rational Choice Theory: A Crime Related Perspective; Self Control Theory; Sutherland, Edwin H.

REFERENCES AND SUGGESTED READINGS

- Cleckley, H. J. (1976) *The Mask of Sanity*, 5th edn. C. V. Mosby, St. Louis, MO.
Eysenck, H. J. (1977) *Crime and Personality*, 3rd edn. Routledge & Kegan Paul, London.

- Glueck, S. & Glueck, E. (1950) *Unraveling Juvenile Delinquency*. Harper & Row, New York.
Gottfredson, M. & Hirschi, T. (1990) *A General Theory of Crime*. Stanford University Press, Stanford.
Hare, R. D. (1980) A Research Scale for the Assessment of Psychopathy in Criminal Populations. *Personality and Individual Differences* 1: 111-19.
Hirschi, T. & Hindelang, M. J. (1977) Intelligence and Delinquency: A Revisionist Review. *American Sociological Review* 42: 571-87.
Kohlberg, L. (1969) *Stages in the Development of Moral Thought and Action*. Holt, Rinehart, & Winston, New York.

crime, radical/Marxist theories of

Barbara Sims

Marxist criminological theory asserts that crime is the result of structural inequalities that are inherently associated with capitalist economic systems. Although Marx himself wrote very little about crime, theorists have relied on his economic theory to provide a foundation for a *critical* theory of criminal behavior. Marx believed that throughout history, human societies have consisted of two classes: those who have the power to create the rules under which everyone must live, and those who have neither the resources nor the political clout to have a say in just what those rules will be. Examples of these economic or political systems are master versus slave, lord versus serf, and, under modern day capitalism, capitalist versus proletariat. The capitalists are those who own the means of production, and the proletariats are those who work for them.

Marx used a base structure metaphor to describe the role of social institutions, with the economic mode of production providing the base of that structure. For Marx, the mode of production determines the characteristics of other social institutions, e.g., the social, political, and spiritual institutions.

Marxist criminologists argue that a society where some people, because of their place in the capitalist system, are able to accrue a great deal of wealth and material goods, and some are

not, is setting itself up for criminal behavior. Such behavior results from a lack of attention by those in power to the growing tensions among the working classes, who see a great divide between what the culture teaches them they can, and should, achieve, and the actual opportunities that could assist them in such achievement.

Intellectually, critical theorists rely on Marx's notion of exploitation of the working class by the capitalists to further explain growing frustrations by the former and rebellion, some of which could be criminal in nature. The capitalist class is able to earn extraordinary rates of surplus value, the profit produced by the workers for the capitalists, made possible through the labor of the worker. The workers are paid a subsistence living wage, barely enough to feed, clothe, and shelter themselves and, when relevant, their families.

At the time Marx was writing, the Industrial Revolution was underway with untold accounts of workers being injured or killed in the factories because of unsafe working conditions. Further, men, women, and children were being worked long hours in the factories of the capitalists, and in some cases suffered the lash of their supervisors should their work be deemed not to be of sufficient quality. The growing working class was increasingly viewed by Marx as exploited and, arguably, a powder keg about to explode.

Modern day Marxist theorists argue that although much has changed in the world since Marx's writings, there is still room for improvement when it comes to the working class. Neo Marxists, for example, suggest that although a revolution and the overthrow of the capitalist economy is not an appropriate solution to the problem of worker exploitation and gross inequalities of opportunity, there is much that could be done to reduce the boiling tensions and frustrations of the have nots in society. The minimum wage could be increased to an amount established by leading economists, factoring in the costs of food, clothing, and shelter in today's economy. Job creation and training programs could be established in local communities hit hard by the outsourcing of manufacturing sector employment to foreign markets. Assistance to families could take many forms. For one, subsidized and quality day care for the children of the working class could alleviate the stress of

worrying about who will take care of the children while the parents are at work. Medical leave with pay for workers who become unable to work or who have a family member in need of assistance could reduce the stress of worrying about missed wages or losing one's job because of an unexpected turn of events. Government sponsored health care programs that provide quality health care to the working class could also relieve much of the stress associated with worries over how to take care of oneself or one's family should illnesses or injuries occur.

On another level, Marxist criminologists argue that the criminal justice system, the system through which people who break the law are processed, should become more equitable. There should be an expectation that all individuals who come in contact with the system will be treated justly and equitably, with the rich receiving the same treatment as the poor. A system where "the rich get richer and the poor get prison" (Reiman 2001) should be abolished once and for all. Corporate fraud, or suite crime, that bilks retirement funds from longtime and loyal employees should be punishable by hard prison time no less than crimes of the street. When differences exist between the haves and the have nots when it comes to the meting out of justice, it becomes clear that the system is, in fact, unjust. Increasingly, members of the lower class, sometimes referred to as the truly disadvantaged, view the system as broken, and act out in ways that are hurtful to society.

One area that has always interested Marxist criminologists is the relationship between economic inequality and crime. Beginning with Willem Bonger (1969), Marxist theorists have attempted to demonstrate the relationship between economic inequality and crime. For Bonger, egoism is the result of the inherent ruthlessness of capitalism and its underlying competitiveness to get ahead by any means necessary. Members of the working class are forced to live in sometimes brutal conditions, and, at the same time, have the ruling class inculcating the culture with images of materialistic success. In this type of environment, the good of the whole is not considered, and altruism that would lead to prosocial attitudes and behaviors cannot take root. Richard Quinney, while agreeing with Bonger that capitalism causes crime, also pointed attention toward the

crimes of the ruling class. Those crimes are price fixing, political corruption, police brutality, violation of citizens' civil rights, and so on. According to Quinney, the ruling class must engage in actions of this sort in order to maintain the existing system.

In the 1980s and the 1990s, critical theorists, relying heavily on Marxist notions, continued to look at the relationship between structural inequalities and crime, and continued to examine more closely the crimes of the powerful. In an effort to demonstrate the importance of structural variables on individual interactions within the existing culture, Colvin and Pauly created an integrated structural Marxist theory of delinquency. They argued, and were able to demonstrate through an empirical test of their theoretical model, that parents discipline their children along the same lines as they themselves are treated within the workplace by their employers. Those who are supervised by employers who use coercive methods to obtain conformity in their workers use coercive methods in the household, as opposed to egalitarian means, to obtain conformity in their children.

Sims (1997) has argued that a well received theoretical model developed by Messner and Rosenfeld (1997) does not go far enough in explaining the role that social institutions play in the production of violent crime in America. The sociological paradigm developed by Messner and Rosenfeld does include strain theory and social disorganization theory, with a discussion of how inequality in opportunity within social institutions that are in disarray creates a society ripe for crime. What is left out, however, is the inclusion of Marxist criminology that can explain how social institutions are formed and function within the capitalist society. Sims (1997) argues that the economic foundation sets the stage for both the cultural messages received by the populace and the environment in which social interaction takes place. Marxist concepts can be used to add the missing link to Messner and Rosenfeld's model of crime.

Since the early 1960s, Marxist theories of crime have spawned several new theories, each bringing forth new ideas about the problem of crime. Left realism addresses the increasingly repressive control of the state over individuals who engage in lawbreaking, and calls for a closer look at the toll that crime takes on

individuals and communities. Feminist theory asserts that women continue to take a backseat to males in a patriarchal system, calling for studies that consider gender constructs in research designs. This approach would be one that goes beyond simply adding the variable *gender* to studies of crime and deviance and that demonstrates a clear understanding of the role that culture and social conditions contribute to society's views of and attitudes toward women. Peacemaking criminology attacks the militaristic approach to crime control, agitating for a system that looks toward an end to the "war on crime" and/or the "war on drugs" and the ushering in of a system in which all sides can live in peaceful coexistence with one another.

At the core of all of these theoretical perspectives, however, are basic Marxist principles. In sum, the economic mode of production dictates how the other social institutions will function. Although they may shift and do have some degree of autonomy, the economic foundation does not allow for too great a deviation from the base structure. The economy, then, takes a front seat to such institutions as the family, schools, the polity, and the spiritual. Under capitalism, a two class system emerges with a heavy emphasis on materialism and extreme competitiveness. The ruling class, those who own the means of production, are able to exploit the working class, and those who are most likely to suffer under this type of system are the poor, minorities, women, and children. At the same time, the ruling class is able to focus society's attention on the crimes of the lower classes while engaging in behavior that is corrupt, but that allows them to stay in power.

While some suggest that Marxist theories are somewhat utopian, other theorists see the importance of the contribution of the concepts of Marx to a more comprehensive examination of crime and delinquency. They argue continually that to ignore the more proximate (e.g., macro or structural) variables in any theoretical model of crime, in light of the fact that it is the more distal variables (e.g., micro or individual) that seemingly explain more in a multivariate (predictive) statistical model, is to miss the point. It is the way society is structured that determines the form that the social institutions take and the culture that arises out of interactions with individuals within those institutions.

SEE ALSO: Capitalism; Feminist Criminology; Marx, Karl; New Left Realism; Peacemaking; Stratification and Inequality

REFERENCES AND SUGGESTED READINGS

- Bonger, W. (1969) *Criminality and Economic Conditions*. Indiana University Press, Indiana.
- Caringella-MacDonald, S. (1997) Taking Back the Critical: Reflections on the Division of Critical Criminology in Light of Left Realism, Feminism, Postmodernism, and Anarchism. *Critical Criminologist* 7(2/3): 22–4.
- Cohen, L. E. & Felson, M. (1979) Social Change and Crime Rate Trends: A Routine Activity Approach. *American Sociological Review* 44: 588–608.
- Grose, G. & Groves, W. B. (1988) Crime and Human Nature: A Marxist Perspective. *Contemporary Crises* 12: 145–71.
- Groves, W. B. & Sampson, R. J. (1987) Traditional Contributions to Radical Criminology. *Journal of Research in Crime and Delinquency* 24(3): 181–214.
- Lynch, M. & Groves, W. B. (1989) *A Primer in Radical Criminology*, 2nd edn. Harrow & Heston, New York.
- Messner, S. F. & Rosenfeld, R. (1997) *Crime and the American Dream*, 2nd edn. Wadsworth, Belmont, CA.
- Reiman, J. (2001) *The Rich Get Richer and the Poor Get Prison*. Allyn & Bacon, Boston.
- Sims, B. (1997) Crime, Punishment, and the American Dream: Toward a Marxist Integration. *Journal of Research in Crime and Delinquency* 34(1): 5–24.
- Taylor, I., Walton, P., & Young, J. (1973) *The New Criminology: For a Social Theory of Deviance*. Harper & Row, New York.
- Weiner, R. R. (1981) *Cultural Marxism and Political Sociology*. Sage, Beverly Hills, CA.
- Wilson, W. J. (1988) *The Truly Disadvantaged: The Inner City, the Underclass, and Public Policy*. University of Chicago Press, Chicago.
- Wolff, R. (1984) *Understanding Marx: A Reconstruction and Critique of Capital*. Blackwell, Oxford.

crime, schools and

Thomas W. Brewer and Daniel J. Flannery

The majority of schools in America are safe places. A comparison of national data from 1995 and 2001 shows the percentage of students

who reported being victims of crime at school decreased by 4 percent (DeVoe et al. 2003). In 1999 the US Departments of Education and Justice reported that almost 90 percent of all in school student injuries that required medical treatment were accidental, rather than the result of intentional acts of physical violence. Schools see fewer homicides and non fatal injuries than homes or neighborhoods. From 1992 to 2000, school aged youth were 70 times more likely to be murdered outside of school than in school (US Department of Education 2001). The violence that does occur in schools, however, has changed. Serious violent acts are now more common than in the past. In the 1940s, school discipline problems generally involved running in the halls, chewing gum, talking out of turn, and other unruly behavior. In the 1970s, discipline problems progressed to dress code violations; in the 1980s, fighting became a concern. By the 1990s, school problems were defined as weapons possession, drug and alcohol abuse, gang activity, truancy, and violent assaults against students and teachers.

In schools, violence occurs along an age graded continuum. With younger children, violence is manifest as aggressive behavior such as kicking, hitting, or name calling. As children grow older, however, violent behavior becomes more serious and is characterized by assaults against other students and teachers, sexual harassment, gang activity, or carrying a weapon.

Students are not the only victims of violence at school; teachers can be targets as well. Between 1997 and 2001, on average, 21 out of every 1,000 teachers were victims of violent school crime; however, only 2 out of 1,000 teachers were likely to be victims of serious violent offenses such as robbery, aggravated assault, or sexual assault. Teachers in urban schools were more likely to be victims of violent crime than teachers in suburban or rural districts (DeVoe et al. 2003).

To minimize violence at school, it is important to understand the risk factors for violent behavior, so that effective school based prevention and intervention programs can be implemented. This is no easy task, however, as risk factors are complex and multidimensional, and may change over time. In addition, factors